

A PACT WITH THE DEVIL

witchcraft under scrutiny

According to the mythology that grew around witchcraft in the medieval era, witches, whether female or male, rejected the Christian faith and made a voluntary and subservient pact with the Devil. Some women were said to have had sex with the Devil in exchange for magical powers. The pacts were formal, sometimes taking the form of a written contract, and came to be used as the cornerstone of many prosecutions. Witches performed *maleficium* (harmful magic), too, and behaved unnaturally—flying, for example. They might also change into wolves, have marks on their bodies, and even practice incest or cannibalism. Such alleged behavior varied from place to place, depending on local tradition.

Divided opinions

In the early years of Christianity, witchcraft was looked upon as a perilous hangover from pagan times. Indeed, Augustine of Hippo in about 400 CE insisted that witchcraft was an illusion: it did not exist. In 643, Rothari, king of Lombardy, issued an edict saying, “Let nobody presume to kill a foreign serving maid or female slave as a witch, for it is not possible, nor ought to be believed by Christian minds.” Two centuries on, however, opinion was divided. On the one hand, bishops at the Council

of Paris in 829 decided that witchcraft was so dangerous that it should be punishable by death. Soon after, the Scots king Kenneth MacAlpin declared that all sorcerers and witches should be burned at the stake. On the other hand, the Canon Episcopi of 900 still declared that witchcraft was a delusion, and stated, for instance, that when women claimed to fly upon broomsticks at night, it was due to the Devil’s mind tricks.

Targeting the weak

As the medieval era progressed, accusations of witchcraft increased. However, hardly any of those accused of witchcraft, female or male, practiced any form of magic, let alone witchcraft in the way scholars and Church men understood it—as a conspiracy between humans and demons to overthrow Christendom, and so a worse crime than *maleficium* alone. The accused was often poor and vulnerable, someone seen as an enemy wreaking havoc within the community or alternatively an outsider, such as a vagrant or beggar. Those charged were invariably persecuted.



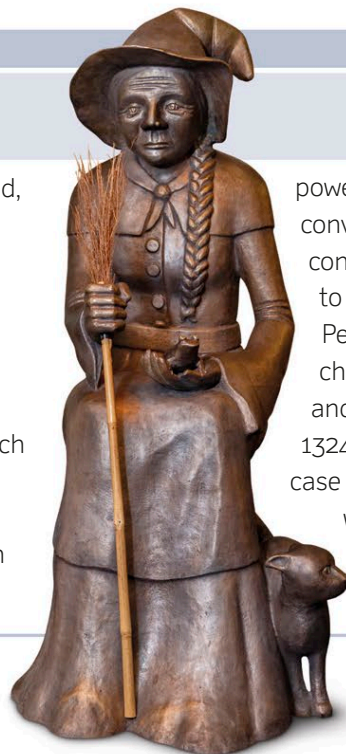
▲ Ways of the wicked

A witch summons a demon with three animal heads in this woodcut c. 1550 from Sebastian Münster’s *Cosmographia*, the first work in German to attempt to describe the whole world.

ALICE KYTELER (1263–AFTER 1325)

Rich witch

In 1324, Alice Kyteler of Kilkenny, Ireland, (represented as a witch in a modern statue at Kilkenny’s Kyteler Inn, right) became the first woman tried for witchcraft as a heretic, and the first to be tried for acquiring magical powers by having sex with the Devil. Alice had become rich by marrying four times, each time taking control of her husband’s business. Charges of witchcraft were brought against her by her stepchildren who believed she had used demonic



powers to seduce their fathers. She was convicted, but had enough influential connections to flee the country, never to be seen again. Her maidservant Petronilla de Meath, however, was charged with being Alice’s accomplice and burned at the stake on November 3, 1324, for heresy. Scholars find Alice’s case interesting not just because of the witchcraft but also because of the way it shows women could manage businesses at this time.